The Lighthouse at Hollow Bay

A DEMO STORY

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“Every page is a small door.
Turn it gently.”

Written for the Turn the page demo. Free to share.

CHAPTER ONE

The Keeper's Cat

The lighthouse at Hollow Bay had been kept by the same family for four generations, and by the same cat for what felt like longer. Her name was Marrow. She was grey as sea fog, with one white paw she liked to keep tucked out of sight, as if it were a secret she had not yet decided to share.

Every evening, when Ada climbed the hundred and twelve steps to wind the great lamp, Marrow climbed them too, three steps ahead and never once looking back. At the top she would sit on the brass rail and watch the beam go out across the water, slow and sure, like a hand smoothing a blanket.

“You'd make a better keeper than me,” Ada told her one night. The cat blinked, which Ada chose to take as agreement.

The village below knew the light the way it knew the church bell and the baker's whistle. Fishermen set their courses by it. Children were told that as long as it turned, nothing truly bad could find its way into the harbour.

Ada did not believe that, exactly. But she believed in oiling the gears on Tuesdays, trimming the wick on Fridays, and keeping a pot of tea warm for whoever might knock on the door after dark. Mostly it was nobody. Once, it had been a heron.

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CHAPTER TWO

A Letter in the Fog

The letter arrived on a morning so thick with fog that the postman had to follow the sound of the bell buoy to find the path. It was addressed in careful, old-fashioned handwriting to “The Keeper, Hollow Bay Light,” and it smelled faintly of cedar.

Ada read it twice at the kitchen table while Marrow sat on the windowsill pretending not to be interested. A ship, the letter said, would be passing the point on the night of the first storm of autumn. Its lamps were old. Its captain was older.

“Keep the light burning,” the letter finished, “and we shall find our way home.” There was no name at the bottom, only a small drawing of a cat with one white paw.

Ada looked at Marrow. Marrow looked at the ceiling.

That afternoon Ada carried up extra oil, two spare wicks and a flask of tea. She checked the clockwork twice and the shutters three times. When the wind began to rise in the late afternoon, she found she was not afraid of it, only ready.

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CHAPTER THREE

The Long Night

The storm came in sideways, hurling rain against the lantern glass until the whole tower hummed. Ada kept to her chair beside the lamp, winding the clockwork every hour, and Marrow kept to the rail, ears flat, eyes fixed on the dark.

A little after midnight the cat stood up. Far out past the point, low on the water, a small light blinked once, then again: a ship, feeling its way along the edge of the beam.

Ada held her breath and turned the lamp a fraction brighter. The little light steadied, swung wide of the rocks, and slid safely past into the sheltered water of the bay.

By morning the storm had blown itself out. On the doorstep sat a parcel of cedar wood, and inside it a brass collar tag engraved with a single word: *Keeper*.

Marrow allowed it to be fastened, just this once, and went to sleep in the sun.

The End